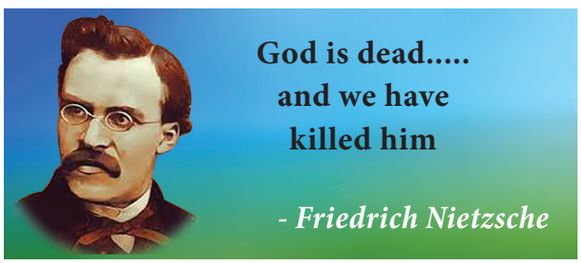
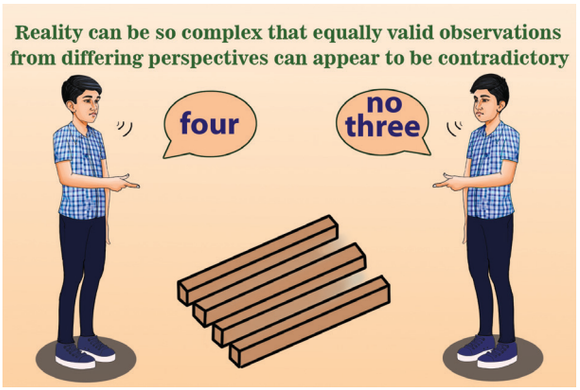
9.4 Postmodernism

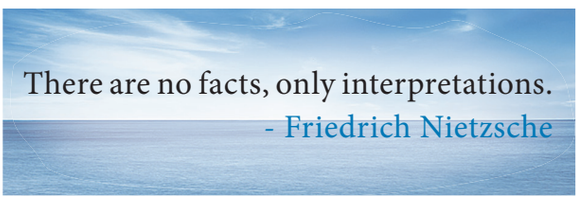
Postmodernism refers to a variety of ideas that criticize modernity and emerge as its successor and rival. The major proponents of Postmodernism include Fredrick Nietzsche, Jean-Francois Lyotard, Michel Foucalt and Jacques Derrida. Modernity has dominated the political theory in the last 200 years. Rationality, universalism, reductionism are among the dominant principles of modernity. Postmodernism challenges these principles and advocates alternatives. It emerged in the last three decades in western political theory.



Fredrick Nietzsche is called Father of Post Modernism. He famously said "God is dead". Modernity believes in universalism and reductionism. It explains all the phenomena through a single factor or one ultimate truth. For example, Karl Marx said human life depends on economy and all problems can be solved by eliminating the right to private property. Similarly Fredrick Hegel, the German philosopher argued that the world is nothing but the embodiment of World Spirit. Postmodernism, in contrast, advocates that the world and our life is complex and cannot be explained by a single factor. A host of factors like culture, language, religion, politics, and economy decide human life and this world.



Postmodernism believes that truth is not singular but plural. There are multiple versions of truth. For example, take any one leader or historical event. Different people will talk about the leader or the event differently. One person may call that leader a visionary. Another may call him a demagogue. Yet another may have a different perspective. All may be right in their own perspective and interpretation. The world is not constituted only by the two colours of black and white. There are more colours positioned in a continuum in between black and white.



Jacque Derrida was a French philosopher who advocated an innovative Post- modern concept called deconstruction. He provides deconstruction as an approach to understand meanings and texts. There are multiple meanings in a text and as human language is not so developed it may not be possible for the author of a text to communicate all his thoughts and the receiver or reader of the text may understand the meanings differently.

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